STREET DANCE AND URBAN DANCE

STUDIO

DANCE CORE

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WHAT IS STREET DANCE

Street dance is a broad term for dance styles that originated outside of traditional dance studios, usually in urban environments like streets, clubs, or schoolyards. These styles are often linked to hip hop culture, but also include other genres that came from social and community settings.

Key Features of Street Dance:

- Improvised and freestyle-based (not fully choreographed)
- Rooted in community, expression, and individuality
- Often performed in battles or cyphers (dance circles)
- Emphasizes musicality, groove, and attitude
- Developed organically from everyday people, not professional dancers

Popular Street Dance Styles:

- Breaking (B-boying/B-girling) – acrobatic, floor-based moves; started in the Bronx.
- Popping – involves sharp muscle contractions (pops) to the beat.
- Locking – features quick freezes and exaggerated movements.
- Krumping – intense and expressive, born in South Central L.A.
- Hip Hop Freestyle – mixes various moves, emphasizing rhythm and flow.
- House Dance – footwork-heavy, danced to house music, often with fluid movements.
- Litefeet – fast, energetic, and playful; originated in NYC.
- Waacking & Voguing – expressive arm movements, originated in LGBTQ+ club scenes.

What is Waacking?

Waacking is a high-energy street dance style that started in the LGBTQ+ clubs of Los Angeles during the 1970s disco era. It's known for its expressive, dramatic, and rhythmic arm movements, often performed to disco, funk, or house music.

Here are its key features:

- Arm "whacks" – Fast, circular, or snapping arm movements that hit sharp poses in time with the music.
- Posing & drama – Striking strong poses like in fashion modeling, inspired by Hollywood movie stars and magazine covers.
- Expressive storytelling – Using body language, attitude, and facial expressions to communi cate emotion.
- Footwork & spins – While arms are the highlight, dancers also use steps, turns, and floor work to add flair.

It grew as a way for marginalized communities—especially queer Black and Latinx dancers—to express individuality, confidence, and freedom. Today, waacking appears in dance battles, stage performances, and even music videos, but it still carries that bold, unapologetic personality from its disco roots.

What is Voguing?

Voguing is a stylized modern dance that originated in the Harlem ballroom scene of the 1980s, created primarily by Black and Latinx LGBTQ+ communities. It's inspired by poses from fashion magazines like Vogue, hence the name.

Main elements of voguing:

- Posing – Striking sharp, angular poses like a model, often in rapid succession.
- Lines & shapes – Using arms, legs, and body to create clean geometric forms.
- Floor performance – Dramatic slides, dips, and spins on the floor.
- Dips / "death drops" – Sudden, controlled falls into a low, dramatic position.
- Catwalks & runway walks – Fashion-show-style walking with attitude.

Voguing is more precise and angular compared to waacking's flowing, circular arm motions. It's not just a dance—it's tied to a whole culture of ball competitions, where categories go beyond dance into fashion, realness, and performance art.

WHAT iS URBAN DANCe

Urban dance is a broad term used to describe modern dance styles that evolved in street, club, and community settings, rather than formal dance studios. It's not a single style, but rather an umbrella for many street-originated forms, especially those connected to hip hop and funk culture.

Key points about urban dance:

- Origins – Developed in cities and community gatherings, often among youth expressing identity, creativity, and resistance.
- Main styles – Includes hip hop dance, breaking, popping, locking, krumping, house dance, waacking, voguing, and more.
- Music connection – Typically danced to hip hop, R&B, funk, house, or electronic music.
- Cultural roots – Deeply tied to African American, Latinx, and LGBTQ+ communities, who shaped these forms in social and battle settings.
- Expression – Focuses on individuality, freestyle improvisation, and storytelling through movement.
- Modern use – Today, "urban dance" is also used in choreography-based communities (like those on YouTube and in dance studios), though purists sometimes prefer "street dance" to keep the cultural connection strong.

In short, urban dance is the living, evolving family of street-born dance styles, shaped by music, community, and cultural exchange.

Quick Comparison Table

Feature	Street Dance	Urban Dance
Origin	Streets, clubs, community gatherings	Street styles + studio/choreography fusion
Main focus	Freestyle, cultural authenticity	Performance, visual presentation
Examples	Breaking, popping, locking, waacking	Choreographed hip hop, fusion routines
Setting	Cyphers, battles, parties	Classes, competitions, stage, online
Connection to music	Deeply tied to the culture of the music	May mix different genres for choreography

Here's the **street dance → urban dance evolution** in a clear table format:

Era	Street Dance Styles	Urban Dance Development
1970s–1980s	Breaking (NYC) Popping & Locking (California) Waacking (LA disco clubs) House Dance (Chicago & NYC clubs) Voguing (Harlem ballroom)	Mostly raw street culture, freestyle battles, community gatherings
1990s	Krumping (LA) Litefeet (NYC)	Street styles start entering studios; street jazz & hip hop choreo emerge
2000s–2010s	Existing street styles still active	YouTube era → Choreographers blend street styles with jazz, contemporary, and commercial dance; term "Urban Dance" becomes popular
Today	All original street styles still practiced	Urban dance = Street styles + Studio choreography + Online trends (K-pop, TikTok, stage performances)